would join the next emperor but many would be dismissed, left to peddle their wares in the bazaars and markets of the kingdom. Some would join the households of the great amirs of the empire like Abdur Rahim, Aziz Koka, Bahadur Khan Uzbek, and also Raja Man Singh, Raja Bir Singh Budela, Rao Surjan Singh Hara of Bundi, Rana Amar Singh of Udaipur as well as the rulers of Jaisalmer, Jodhpur, and Bikaner. According to art historian Asok Kumar Das, 'these rulers constructed new palaces in their respective capitals, borrowing heavily from Mughal architectural features, like elaborate murals on the inner walls of chambers and halls and decorations on the dados, facades and chhajas. Traces of these are still visible in the forts and palaces of Amer, Orchha, Datia and Bundi and on the garden pavilion of Bairat and in some havelis in Rajasthan, Haryana, Punjab and Madhya Pradesh.' Akbar had dreamed of a new Hindustani identity, merging local painting idioms with a Persian one. This luminous Mughal identity would slowly sweep back into the provincial courts, brightening up local styles like a comet trail of light.

As the Padshah began to slip away, the last of the imperial workshops grew quiet, and the noise of construction ceased. Only the animals remained: the lumbering elephants, the watchful cheetahs, and the loving dogs. The harem remained, too, and a small coterie of attendants, faithful to the last. The Jesuits had again tried one last time to visit with the Padshah but had been turned away by the noblemen guarding the fort. The Jesuits maintained that the attendants were trying to remind the dying emperor of the need to utter Prophet Muhammad's name, but that he had made no sign of assent, though Akbar tried to whisper the name of God. What they may have been doing, however, was quietly muttering the kalima. 'In the end,' wrote the Jesuits, for fear of the Padshah 'neither [Muslims] nor [Hindus] nor Christians would claim him as theirs, so that he had the prayers of none.'

At the other end of the city, in Salim's palace, there was a great clamour. The raucous crowds of men were loud in their congratulations and frenzied in their attempts to carve out a place for themselves in the new order. The drummers began a deafening, frenetic beat but Salim quickly silenced them, so as not to disturb the peace of his father's last night with such obscene joy. The world knew the Padshah had died when a long, aching lamentation spilled out from the women's quarters in the middle of the watchful night.